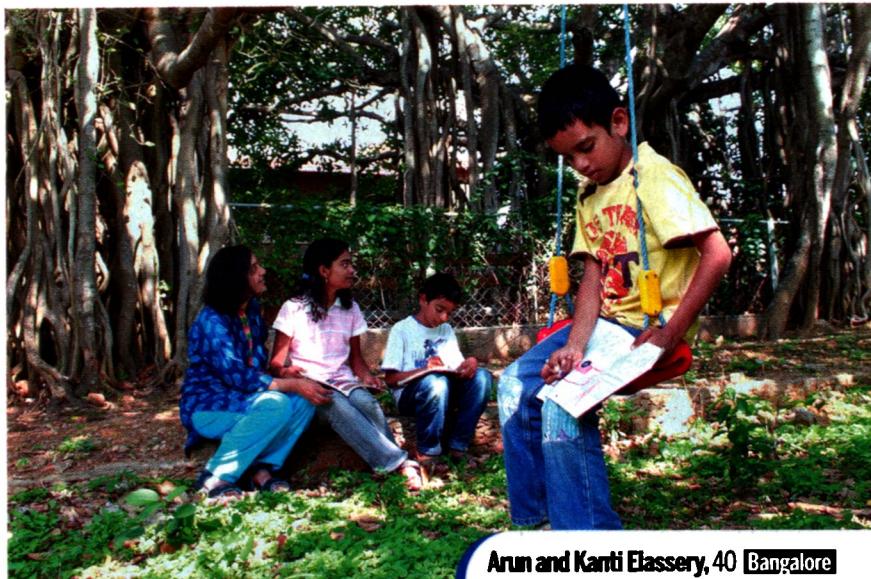


**KANTI WITH DAUGHTER ADITI
AND SONS SRIKANT AND DINKAR**

pluck his daughter Aditi, 14, out of school as a part of their developmental journey. This irrian and his wife, who is a computer science graduate, don't believe in the conventional models of success and failure that drive most people. "We were convinced that we did not learn much in the educational institute and then we found a network of home schoolers in Bangalore. So we decided to move so that there would be a community of home-schoolers around," says Arun.

Broadly, Elassery's children follow the NCERT curriculum, designed for the CBSE. After their morning yoga, the children spend a couple of hours studying different subjects. Both parents have split the responsibility of teaching different subjects. Later, the children are left to do their own thing. The couple believes that they are a few years away from deciding whether the children will appear for board exams or not. Aditi is neutral about her parent's decision to pluck her out of school. While she's happy that being at home gives her the chance to pursue other things like dance and photography, she says she would not mind going to school or college in time to come. "I don't mind not having too many friends," says Aditi.

The social impact of home schooling is what many critics are concerned about. With the atmosphere at school, children become more social through their interactions with peers and elders alike, but in a home environment, they may be deprived of a peer network. Perhaps this is the reason many are moving to cities like Bangalore where there is



an active network of families which practise home schooling. But the Elasserys believe that it has not made much of a difference to them as those who opt for home schooling have to be very confident about what they are doing and believe it's for the better.

But where does home schooling leave these children? There are some parents who want to shield their children from the stress of exams and, therefore, are schooling their children at home. These children can apply for a permission to appear for secondary school exams under the National Open School Programme and give exams like any other student. Ruchir Raju Deepti, for instance, who neither went to school nor has followed any curriculum, has

Arun and Kanti Elassery, 40 Bangalore

After leaving successful careers, Arun and his wife set out on a journey of self-discovery. Accompanying them are their three children, who don't go to school and follow a learning process driven by their inherent interests.

We are not doing this to rebel against the system but because we believe we can do it better.

ARUN ELASSERY

given his secondary and higher secondary exams under the same, but has chosen to do a vocational course in animation instead of going to college. But there are many who are not sure if they want to be bound by the conventional system at all and would much rather be like Aamir Khan's character in the film *3 Idiots*.

Clearly, home schooling is here to stay and in the times to come, many more people will opt for it despite the Right to Education Act. Educational experts like Ramaswamy believe that a lot more people will opt for it in the near future as conventional schooling does not meet the varied needs of all children and because tools like online tutoring are fast becoming popular. Also, children who are brighter than others may find the pace of regular schools stifling. The jury may still be out on de-schoolers, who will perhaps never have a degree pronouncing them as knowledgeable, but the question mark on the relevance of India's educational system will remain. ■

THE NARAYANANS WITH THEIR DAUGHTER

R. Satya and Uma Narayanan, 40 Bangalore

The couple decided to pull out their daughter Anandita, 8, out of school last year as they believe that conventional educational system does not help a child attain his or her dreams.

Schooling does not necessarily equal education, but it should provide a sense of adequacy.

R. SATYA NARAYANAN

